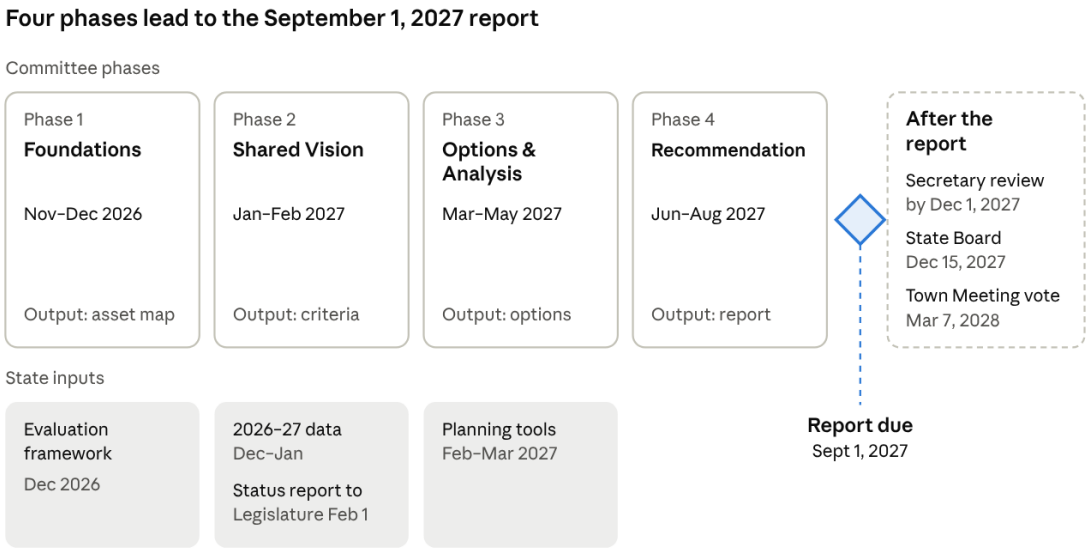
Burlington - South Burlington - Winooski Merger Study Committee

DRAFT Committee Work Plan

This plan sequences the committee's work in four phases, from November 2026 to the September 1, 2027 report deadline.

Key dates



Information from the AOE (see enclosed memo with the meeting materials) indicates when we should expect to see state data and tools. This work plan is designed to align the phases with the release of that information.

Phases of work

Phase 1: Foundations (November–December 2026)

Focus: a shared picture of where our three districts stand today.

- Ensure a shared understanding of what every district must provide: federal obligations, the Education and District Quality Standards, and graduation requirements.
- Complete the regional asset map (begins November 2).
- Review data that is already available, and identify strengths, gaps and differences in opportunity across the three districts.
- Begin community engagement through each district's existing channels.
- Start an open questions and assumptions log.

Output: asset map findings, a summary of current conditions in each district, and an initial questions log.

Phase 2: Shared Vision and Opportunities (January–February 2027)

Focus: what our communities could accomplish together.

- Review the state's Quality Evaluation Framework (expected December 2026) and agree how the committee will use it.
- Name the committee's own evaluation criteria, including any values not captured by the state framework.
- Define the educational opportunities a regional district should offer every student, and which local strengths must be protected.
- Begin the required consultation with area career and technical education (CTE) directors.

Output: a draft shared vision statement and the committee's evaluation criteria.

Phase 3: Options and Analysis (March–May 2027)

Focus: how best to organize to achieve the vision.

- Define the governance options to compare, including no merger.
- Use the state's financial, staffing and scenario-planning tools (expected February–March 2027).
- Analyze staffing, facilities, transportation, special education and CTE access under each option.
- Model finances under the new foundation formula. Keep current spending and one-time transition costs separate.
- Hold community forums on the options under study.

Output: a comparison of options against the committee's criteria.

Phase 4: Recommendation and Report (June–August 2027)

Focus: the committee's recommendation and, if a merger is recommended, its terms.

- Reach a recommendation: whether a merger is advisable and, if so, which districts are "necessary" and which are "advisable."
- If recommending a merger, draft the articles of agreement, including board apportionment, debt, property, and the first-year operating plan.
- Prepare the narrative report, including strengths and challenges of current structures, and a minority-view analysis if the recommendation is not unanimous.
- Share the draft publicly for comment before the final vote.

Output: final report and any proposed articles of agreement, due September 1, 2027.

Data and information needs

Information	Source	Available	Needed for	Who gathers
Enrollment, demographics, assessment, attendance, course enrollment	Vermont Education Dashboard	Now	Phase 1	District staff
Long-term weighted ADM (FY27)	AOE	Now	Phases 1, 3	District staff
Per-pupil spending and district financial reports	AOE	Now; FY27 spending per LTWADM not yet published	Phases 1, 3	District staff
Teacher and staff FTE (FY2020–FY2026)	AOE	Now	Phases 1, 3	District staff
Facilities condition (2023 assessment)	School Facilities Dashboard; district facilities records	Now	Phases 1, 3	District staff
Education and District Quality Standards reports; graduation requirements	AOE	Now	Phase 1	Facilitator
Local program offerings, partnerships, student supports	Districts	On request	Phases 1, 2	District staff
Quality Evaluation Framework	AOE and State Board	December 2026 (expected)	Phase 2	Facilitator
2026–27 enrollment and financial data	AOE	December 2026–January 2027 (expected)	Phase 2	District staff
Financial, staffing and scenario-planning tools; equity index	AOE	February–March 2027 (expected)	Phase 3	Facilitator
Transportation data	AOE survey; districts	In development	Phase 3	District staff
Union contracts, debt schedules, property records	Districts	On request	Phase 4	District staff

Role of district staff and technical assistance

District staff provide information; the committee does the analysis and makes the judgments.

District staff (superintendents, business managers and others they designate) can:

- Pull and summarize data for their district using the provided data template.
- Explain local programs, contracts and operations when the committee asks.
- Check figures for accuracy before they enter the committee's record.

Staff attend as members of the public unless the committee requests their participation.

Technical assistance from the Agency of Education is requested through the Facilitator.

Community engagement and open questions

Phase	Engagement purpose
1. Foundations	Hear what students, families, educators and partners value about their schools today
2. Shared Vision	Test the draft vision and criteria with each community
3. Options and Analysis	Present the options under study and gather reactions
4. Recommendation	Public comment on the draft report before the final vote

Each representative shares updates through their own district's channels. The committee may want common materials so all three communities hear the same information.

Open questions and assumptions log

The log records questions the committee can't answer yet, so they are not lost and can be routed to the right source. The facilitator will maintain the log; the committee reviews it at each meeting.

Questions for the committee on November 2

1. Does the four-phase sequence make sense? What would you move, add or drop?
2. How often should we meet, and when do we need longer working sessions?
3. What data should district staff bring to the next meeting?
4. How should we coordinate community engagement across the three districts?